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Autocratization Spillover: When Electing an Authoritarian Erodes Election Trust across Borders

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Abstract The rich literature on election trust predominantly uses domestic determinants as explanatory factors. But given the international nature of the autocratization wave, can an autocratization event across borders erode election trust? This article argues that an authoritarian's electoral success in a neighboring country can shatter democratic norms and demonstrate the viability of authoritarians. This autocratization event abroad can thus reduce citizens' principled support for democracy and its political system. Consequently, citizens across borders are less likely to see democratic elections as the "only game in town" and they have less trust in elections. To test this idea, I study the spillover effects of the 2018 Brazilian presidential election, in which an authoritarian candidate won decisively. Using the AmericasBarometer in Colombia that was launched throughout this election, I find that the election trust of Colombian citizens erodes after Jair Bolsonaro's electoral success. To probe into the mechanism, I uncover that his electoral victory leads Colombian citizens to be less supportive of the domestic political system and reduces their principled support for democracy. The causal mediation analysis demonstrates that these two variables mediate the effect of the authoritarian's electoral success on election trust. These findings on autocratization spillover effects illustrate the importance of external autocratization events in the study of election trust.

Introduction

Election trust is vital for democratic resilience. In analyzing its determinants, scholars predominantly focus on domestic institutional factors or individual factors. Institutional factors include the autonomy of election management

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bodies, media freedom, court rulings, and electoral systems (Birch 2008; Kerr and Lührmann 2017; Kerr and Wahman 2021). Individual factors can be further classified into voter- and elite-level. For voter-level determinants, election trust is affected by voters' partisanship, winner/loser status, and proximity to fraud incidents (Anderson et al. 2005; Alvarez, Hall, and Llewellyn 2008; Daxecker, Di Salvatore, and Ruggeri 2019). On the other hand, studies show that elites' endorsement/challenge of electoral outcomes changes election trust (Hernández-Huerta and Cantú 2022; Clayton and Willer 2023). Noticeably, all these factors are at the domestic level. But considering the international nature of the autocratization wave, can election trust be changed by an external autocratization event that is beyond domestic control? My research answers this question by studying whether election trust is affected by an authoritarian's electoral victories abroad, which often catch worldwide attention.

My research builds upon literature on spillover effects and research on autocratization waves. Recent studies show that an electoral result abroad can change citizens' racist attitudes (Giani and Méon 2021), vote preferences (Turnbull-Dugarte and Rama 2022), vote choices (Delis, Matakos, and Xefteris 2020), and preferences for direct democracy (Steiner and Landwehr 2023). My research joins these works by investigating an unexplored outcome: election trust. The electoral result that I analyze is an authoritarian's electoral victory, which is common in the recent autocratization wave (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). These authoritarians often disrespect judicial and legislature constraints, restrict opponents' civil liberties, and tolerate political violence (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018). Drawing on the autocratization wave literature, I argue that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad shatters democratic norms and demonstrates the viability of authoritarians. Once citizens are exposed to this electoral result, they are more skeptical of their democratic system and their principled support for democracy also decreases. As their democratic support reduces, they are less likely to see democratic elections as the "only game in town" (Linz and Stepan 1996) and have less trust in elections.[1]

To test this argument, I use the 2018 AmericasBarometer in Colombia. This survey was fielded throughout the 2018 Brazilian presidential election, in which Bolsonaro—a far-right authoritarian—won both rounds of the election (Vidigal 2022; Cohen et al. 2023). Assuming the interview's day is random with respect to the election date, I find that Bolsonaro's electoral success erodes election trust in Colombia. To probe into the mechanism, I demonstrate that this autocratization event abroad reduces citizens' support

1. By democratic support, I mean citizens' support for democracy as both principles and political system. This is what Norris (2014) calls "support for general regime principles." This concept is distinct from trust in state institutions, which is more specific, and election trust is one subset.

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for the political system and their principled support for democracy. Furthermore, these two variables mediate the effect of an authoritarian's electoral success on election trust.

The contributions of this research are twofold. First, it brings an international perspective to the literature on election trust. As an authoritarian's electoral success abroad erodes election trust, future studies should pay more attention to foreign autocratization events. Second, my research enriches the debate on autocratization. For one, micro-level studies that analyze why citizens condone authoritarian behavior presume that each country is independent (Graham and Svolik 2020; Frederiksen 2022; Krishnarajan 2022), thus neglecting a foreign autocratization event's impact. For another, scholars who use macro-level indicators often focus on how different countries experience autocratization contemporaneously (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019; Skaaning 2020), instead of their causal relations. My research joins this debate by presenting micro-level causal evidence of how an authoritarian's electoral success abroad reduces democratic support, which consequently erodes election trust.

Why Can Authoritarians' Electoral Success Abroad Erode Election Trust?

Recently, there has been a wealth of studies on the causal impact of electoral results across borders. This literature studies the spillover effect of the Brexit referendum and that of Trump's win/loss. The outcomes include racist attitudes (Giani and Méon 2021), expressed support for the far right (Turnbull-Dugarte and Rama 2022), vote shares of antiestablishment parties (Delis, Matakos, and Xefteris 2020), and preferences for direct democracy (Steiner and Landwehr 2023). These studies claim that electoral results abroad provide information for domestic citizens, who accordingly update their political attitudes.

From these studies, one can expect that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad may change citizens' election trust in two opposite ways. First, an authoritarian's electoral victory may improve election trust across borders. The "benchmarking" literature underpins this expectation (De Vries 2017): as an authoritarian is elected in a foreign country, citizens may have higher trust in domestic elections because their electoral institution does not elect an authoritarian.

Conversely, this autocratization event may erode election trust. One underlying mechanism is "outcome favorability" (Werner 2020; Steiner and Landwehr 2023): citizens lose trust in elections because an authoritarian was elected abroad, an outcome they disfavor. This mechanism suggests that citizens are still principled democrats—their democratic support should remain

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stable. Moreover, it expects left-leaning (right-leaning) citizens to react more strongly when a right-wing (left-wing) authoritarian is elected abroad since the opposite camp should dislike the outcome more.

Another mechanism that explains the erosion of election trust is a decrease in democratic support. Accordingly, if an authoritarian's victory abroad reduces citizens' democratic support, they are less likely to think democratic procedures are the most appropriate way to govern collective life. Put differently, citizens in neighboring countries are less likely to see elections as the "only game in town" (Linz and Stepan 1996), and hence their trust in elections reduces.[2]

I argue that the last observation is most likely. My reasoning is grounded in Huntington's work on spillover. In *The Third Wave*, Huntington argues that democratization and autocratization in one country result in contagion. He suggests that spillover effects are strongest among countries that "were geographically proximate and culturally similar" (1991, p. 102). This spillover argument certainly motivates subsequent macro-level studies that contend regime transitions occur in clusters (Gleditsch and Ward 2006; Houle and Kayser 2019; Goldring and Greitens 2020). Following these insights, I suggest that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad can reduce citizens' democratic support through two complementary ways.

First, an authoritarian's electoral success shatters democratic norms. The majority support obtained by an authoritarian signals that democracy is less mainstream than previously assumed. Consequently, citizens are less bound to support democracy and its political system. Second, like other salient electoral results, an authoritarian's victory abroad sets a precedent for other countries (Jurado, León, and Walter 2022). The electoral victory demonstrates the viability of authoritarians who often cast doubts on democratic systems. Overall, I expect that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad reduces citizens' democratic support, which leads them to be less prone to abide by democratic procedures.[3]

Empirical Strategy and Data

To test this argument, I study the dyad of Colombia-Brazil since spillover is most likely when countries are geographically proximate and share similar regime types (Huntington 1991, p. 293; Goldring and Greitens 2020). The foreign autocratization event is Bolsonaro's victory in the 2018 presidential election. Before this election, Bolsonaro was well known for his authoritarian tendency: he not only defended the former military regime but also

2. Regarding the heterogeneity of this mechanism, I am agnostic about whether left-leaning (right-leaning) citizens decrease election trust more strongly.

3. This mechanism presumes democratic support is theoretically antecedent of election trust.

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praised autocrats like Pinochet and Fujimori (Phillips and Phillips 2018; Cohen et al. 2023). Moreover, during the campaign, he advocated legislation that took away minority protections (Uchoa 2018). Nevertheless, in the first round (October 7), Bolsonaro was the leading candidate by obtaining 46.03 percent of the votes. In the second round (October 28), his vote share reached 55.13 percent, beating the center-left candidate. As Bolsonaro fulfils the authoritarian indicators suggested by Levitsky and Ziblatt (2018), his victory is an important case to test for the autocratization spillover.

The dataset is the 2018 AmericasBarometer in Colombia, consisting of 1,663 respondents that were surveyed via face-to-face interviews with hand-held devices. The sample uses a multistage probability design and is stratified by six geographical regions, with a 27 percent response rate (Lapop 2019). The survey was conducted from September 10 to December 27, 2018. Since the survey was fielded throughout the 2018 Brazil election (27 days before the first-round and 81 days thereafter), this setting can identify the spillover effect. The main outcome is election trust. The question is "To what extent do you trust elections in Colombia?" The answer ranges from "not at all" (1) to "very much" (7), with only endpoints being labeled. To estimate the spillover effect, I use the following model:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{Runoff}_i + \beta_2 \text{Post2nd}_\text{i} + \gamma \boldsymbol{X_i} + \varepsilon_i$$

where i indexes respondents, Y is the dependent variable, and Runoff is a dummy coded as 1 if the interview took place in the runoff period, and 0 otherwise. Likewise, Post2nd is coded as 1 if the interview took place after the second round, and 0 otherwise. A total of 1,050 respondents (63.14 percent) belong to the pre-election group, 77 respondents (4.63 percent) are in the runoff group, and 533 respondents (32.05 percent) are in the post-second-round group. $\boldsymbol{X}$ is a vector of sociodemographic covariates, including age, its square term, gender, education level, income, place of residence, working status, and religion (for exact question wordings and variable operationalization, see Supplementary Material table A.1; for summary statistics, see Supplementary Material tables A.2.1–2.4).[4] My main analysis uses OLS and uses unweighted data. The quantity of interest is β_1 and β_2: β_1 denotes the effect when Bolsonaro became the leading candidate in the runoff, whereas β_2 denotes the effect after he was elected president. I expect that β_1 and β_2 are negative and remain agnostic about whether their difference is statistically significant.

4. Covariate balance tests show that the control group (pre-election group) and the treatment group (runoff and post-second-round group) are symmetrical in age and gender. Yet, there are imbalances for other covariates (Supplementary Material figure A.1). In robustness checks, I use entropy reweighting to create a balanced sample.

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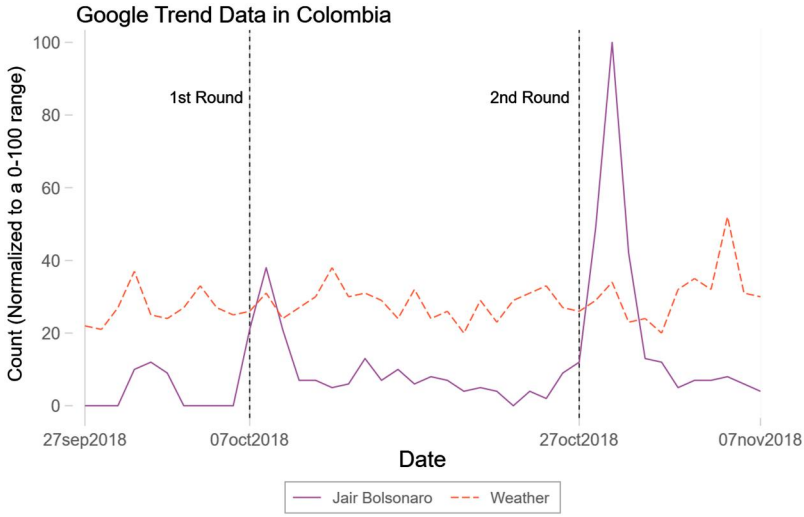

Figure 1. The saliency of the event. The search period is from September 27, 2018 to November 7, 2018. The purple solid line is the search for "Jair Bolsonaro" and the red dotted line is the search for "weather (Spanish: el clima)."

Note that β_1 and β_2 are the covariate-adjusted Intent-to-Treat (ITT) effects, for the survey does not measure direct treatment exposure. Nevertheless, figure 1 illustrates that Colombian citizens were aware of this event, as the search for Bolsonaro spiked after both election rounds. Importantly, the spike was much higher than the search term "weather" after the second round. Moreover, to ensure the effects are not confounded by domestic events, I scraped the headlines of *El Tiempo*—the highest-circulated newspaper in Colombia. Among 683 headlines, there are no domestic events that can substantially change election trust after the first round (see Supplementary Material section D.1).[5]

Next, I use mediation analysis to explore whether the effect of an authoritarian's electoral success on election trust is mediated by the support for the domestic political system and principled support for democracy.[6] The question of the former item is "To what extent do you think that one should support the political system of Colombia?" The scale is the same as that of

5. Another concern is whether Colombian citizens consider Bolsonaro an authoritarian. Supplementary Material section D.2 documents how news in *El Tiempo* depicts Bolsonaro's authoritarian tendency.

6. One mediator that also measures democratic support is the opinion on coups. However, because this item in the survey has two treatment arms, my analysis does not use it.

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election trust. Regarding principled support for democracy, I follow Claassen (2020) and use the "Churchill item": "Democracy may have problems, but it is better than any other form of government. To what extent do you agree or disagree with this statement?" The answer ranges from "strongly disagree" (1) to "strongly agree" (7).[7] The mediation model includes the sociodemographic controls, and I run the model separately for each mediator. One should note that the model depends on the sequential ignorability assumption (Imai et al. 2011): the mediator is independent of the potential outcome given the treatment and pretreatment covariates.

Results

Change in Election Trust

Model 1 of table 1 shows how Bolsonaro's victory changes election trust in Colombia, and figure 2 panel (a) illustrates the predicted level of election trust across three groups. I find that there is a substantive drop in election trust after the first round, in which Bolsonaro was the leading candidate. Compared to the pre-election group, the runoff group is more likely to distrust the election by 0.72 units along a 7-point scale, *ceteris paribus* ($p = 0.002$). As the standard deviation (SD) of the full sample is 1.87, this decrease equals 0.39 SD. Moreover, the erosion of election trust persists after the second round. Compared to the pre-election group, the drop in election trust is 0.54 units among the post-second-round group (0.29 SD, $p = 0.000$). On the other hand, the difference between the runoff group and post-second-round group is indistinguishable ($p = 0.443$).

To substantiate this finding, I restrict the bandwidth to 7 days before and after the first round (September 30 to October 14, 2018). The result is shown in Model 2 in table 1 and figure 2 panel (b). Though the sample is much smaller, the reduction in election trust is similar in magnitude ($p = 0.028$), which vindicates that Bolsonaro's electoral success caused this drop.[8] Also, I restrict the sample to respondents who were surveyed 7 days before the first round (September 30 to October 6, 2018) and the last 7 days of the survey (December 21–27, 2018). As shown in Model 3, the drop in election trust is still clear and is even larger at 1.00 unit (0.53 SD, $p = 0.009$). That means that even after two months of Bolsonaro's victory, the erosion of election trust persists.

7. Graham and Svolik (2020) argue that direct questioning of democratic support fails to account for voters' willingness to trade off democratic principles for partisanship. While not refuting this claim, my idea is that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad reduces citizens' expressed democratic support.

8. Supplementary Material table B.1 shows the finding still holds when the bandwidth is ±4 days.

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Table 1. Spillover effects of Jair Bolsonaro's electoral success (DV: Election trust).

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Runoff	−0.72	−0.65	
	(0.23)	(0.29)	
	$p = 0.002$	$p = 0.028$	
Post2nd	−0.54		−1.00
	(0.11)		(0.38)
	$p = 0.000$		$p = 0.009$
Constant	3.65	4.66	4.08
	(0.42)	(0.97)	(0.99)
	$p = 0.000$	$p = 0.000$	$p = 0.000$
Observations	1,353	249	231
Sample	Full sample	7 days before and after first-round	7 days before first-round and last 7 days of survey
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
R-squared	0.06	0.16	0.19

Note: Entries are coefficients of OLS regression. Standard errors are shown in parentheses. All models include sociodemographic controls (age, square term of age, gender, education level, income, place of residence [rural/urban], working status, and religion).

In the theoretical section, I hinted that the change in election trust can be heterogeneous. As Bolsonaro is a far-right authoritarian, the reception of his electoral success in Colombia may be conditional upon political leaning. In the Supplementary Material, I conduct subgroup analyses by using ideological self-placement and recall vote as moderators (Supplementary Material table B.2).[9] Concerning ideological self-placement, I cannot find any moderating effect (Supplementary Material figure B.1). Concerning recall vote, I find that, in the runoff period, the erosion of election trust occurs only among voters of the right-wing candidate. Yet, in the post-second-round period, the erosion is similar among all citizens (Supplementary Material figure B.2).

As robustness checks, I first use the ordered logit model to confirm that treating the outcome variable as ordinal would not change the result (Supplementary Material table B.3). Second, I use entropy reweighting to

9. Bolsonaro's victory may cause Colombian citizens to shift ideological self-placement and misreport their votes. Readers should be cautious about these subgroup analyses, especially when both moderators are slightly imbalanced (Supplementary Material figure A.1).

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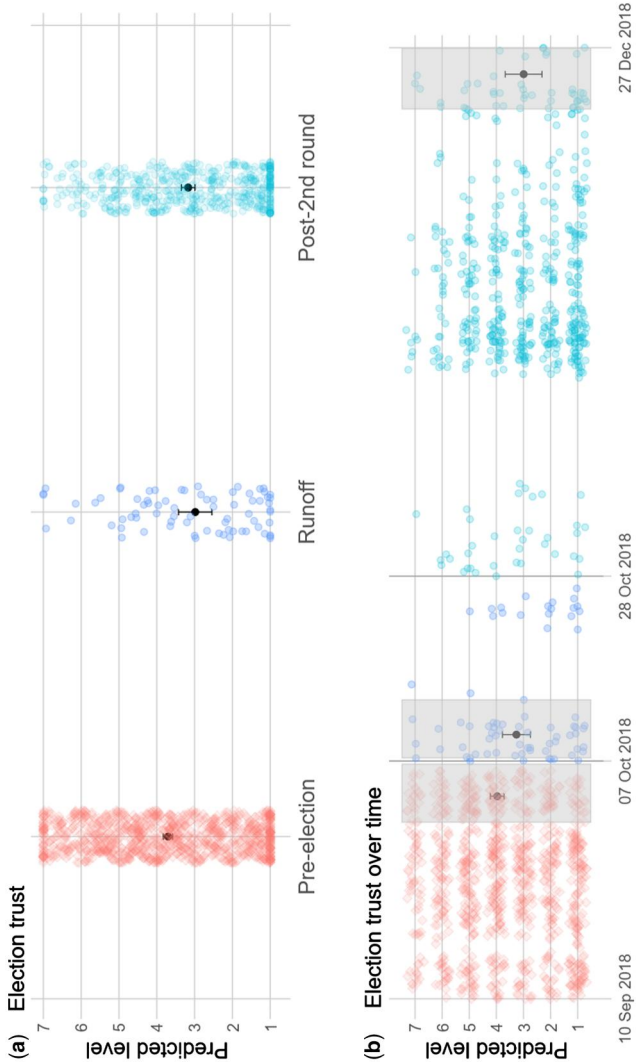

Figure 2. Erosion of election trust. Panel (a) is the predicted election trust across the three groups. The margins plot illustrates the level of election trust based on Model 1 of table 1. Panel (b) is the predicted election trust throughout the survey period. The margins plot illustrates the level of election trust based on Models 2–3 of table 1. The gray areas denote the restricted bandwidth for regressions (7 days). The whiskers show 95 percent confidence intervals.

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deal with covariates imbalance (Hainmueller and Xu 2013) (Supplementary Material table B.4). The findings' substantive interpretation remains the same. Third, I check the outcome's missingness across three groups because an authoritarian's electoral success may change the propensity to answer the election trust question. I cannot find evidence for this (Supplementary Material table B.5). Last, as a placebo test, I repeat the same regression using the 2016 AmericasBarometer in Colombia. Assuringly, no significant effect is identified before Bolsonaro was elected (Supplementary Material table B.6).

Mediation Effect by Democratic Support

The above analysis establishes that election trust in Colombia is reduced after Bolsonaro's electoral success. Yet, this erosion can be explained by "outcome favorability" (Werner 2020; Steiner and Landwehr 2023): Colombian citizens lost trust in elections *only because an authoritarian was elected across borders, an outcome they disfavor*. If this is correct, the support for the political system and the principled support for democracy should remain stable, and these variables do not mediate the effect of Bolsonaro's electoral success. In the following, I reject this optimistic interpretation. Instead, I uncover that the effect of an authoritarian's electoral success on election trust is mediated by both citizens' democratic support.

Figure 3 shows that Bolsonaro's electoral success reduces citizens' support for democracy in Colombia (see Supplementary Material table C.1 for regression results). The left panel illustrates that the post-second-round group expresses less support for the political system than the pre-election group. The magnitude of this drop is 0.46 units along a 7-point scale (0.24 SD, $p = 0.000$). Likewise, the right-panel demonstrates that the post-second-round group is less likely to agree that democracy is better than other forms of government, compared to the pre-election group. The decrease in principled support for democracy is 0.31 units (0.19 SD, $p = 0.002$).[10]

Table 2 reports the causal mediation effects of these two variables. Both citizens' support for the domestic political system and the principled support for democracy mediate the effect of an authoritarian's electoral success. The proportions of the total effect being mediated are 30.0 percent and 13.7 percent, respectively. Hence, the causal mediation analysis demonstrates that an authoritarian's electoral success reduces citizens' democratic support across borders, which in turn erodes their election trust.

10. Supplementary Material part C documents robustness checks for these two mediators, including ordered logit regressions (Supplementary Material table C.2), entropy reweighting (Supplementary Material table C.3), missingness tests (Supplementary Material table C.4), and placebo tests (Supplementary Material table C.5).

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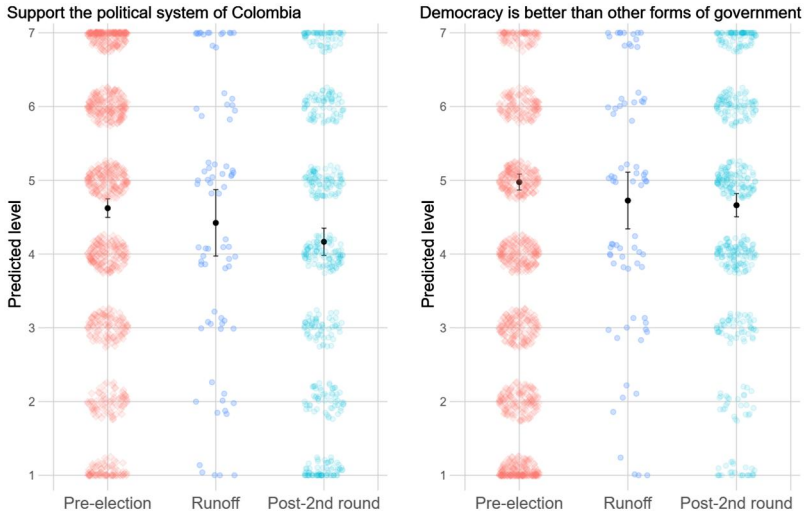

Figure 3. Reduction in democratic support. The left panel is the predicted support for the political system of Colombia across the three groups. The right panel is the predicted principled support for democracy across the three groups. The margins plot illustrates the level of dependent variables based on Models 1 and 2 of Supplementary Material table C.1. The whiskers show 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table 2. Democratic support mediates the effect of authoritarian's electoral success.

	Mediator: support for the political system of Colombia	Mediator: principled support for democracy
Average Causal Mediation Effect (ACME)	−0.167 [−0.255, −0.079] $p = 0.000$	−0.075 [−0.123, −0.026] $p = 0.003$
Average Direct Effect (ADE)	−0.391 [−0.583, −0.198] $p = 0.000$	−0.471 [−0.676, −0.265] $p = 0.000$
Proportion mediated	30.0%	13.7%

Note: The mediator is the support for the political system of Colombia (Column 1) and principled support for democracy (Column 2). Models evaluate the mediation effect and direct effect of Bolsonaro's electoral success on election trust, with the delta method evaluating the statistical significance of the mediation effect. The runoff group and the post-second-round group are combined into one group. All models include sociodemographic controls (age, square term of age, gender, education level, income, place of residence [rural/urban], working status, and religion). The 95 percent confidence intervals are shown in square brackets.

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Discussion

This paper brings an international perspective to the research on election trust. I argue that an authoritarian's electoral success abroad can shatter democratic norms and demonstrate the viability of authoritarians, which reduces citizens' democratic support. Consequently, citizens across borders are less likely to see democratic elections as the "only game in town" and have less trust in elections. I demonstrate this causal chain by studying the Colombia-Brazil dyad. Overall, this research presents first-hand micro-level evidence regarding the spillover effect of an authoritarian's electoral success.

Nevertheless, this research has several limitations. First, it only studies a single country. Though I find that other neighboring countries experienced surges of interest in Bolsonaro (Supplementary Material figure D.3), we are uncertain if their election trust also eroded. Second, Bolsonaro is a far-right authoritarian. So, it is unknown whether a left-wing authoritarian's electoral success would similarly cause autocratization spillovers, as the two ideologies have divergent conceptions of democracy (Slater 2013, 2022). Third, this research cannot determine long-term effects. My analysis demonstrates that the erosion of election trust lasted for two months. Yet, one important question is: After Bolsonaro's loss in the 2022 election, would election trust in Colombia recover?

Despite these limitations, this research should open avenues for future research and has strong policy implications. First, these findings are unsettling because authoritarians' electoral success is beyond domestic control. This raises the puzzle of whether the autocratization tide can be stemmed. If not, autocratization is doomed to spill over. If yes, policymakers should focus on developing policies that help stem the spillover.

Second, the autocratization event of this study is an authoritarian's electoral success. Although an authoritarian's electoral victory is common in the recent autocratization wave (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019), there are other autocratization forms. They range from blatant (military coups, repression, overturning elections) to elusive ones (court-packing, civil liberty restrictions). Do all these autocratization events abroad trigger similar erosion of election trust? Only comparative studies can tell.

Third, this paper studies a dyad that is geographically proximate. Yet, one may ask, "How far can an autocratization event spill over?" The literature suggests that the spillover effects of electoral results need not be restricted to a continent (Giani and Méon 2021; Turnbull-Dugarte and Rama 2022). Therefore, it is promising to study under what sociopolitical contexts autocratization spillover effects are most/least likely to unfold.

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Supplementary Material

Supplementary Material may be found in the online version of this article: https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfae018.

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Data Availability

Replication data and documentation are available at: https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/GPWQIW.

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